

How to Navigate a Course Syllabus

WHAT IS A COURSE SYLLABUS?

A course syllabus is a detailed document that serves as a roadmap for a course, outlining its structure, content, and expectations. Typically provided by the instructor at the beginning of the term, it includes essential information such as course objectives, required materials, grading policies, and a schedule of topics, assignments, and exams. The syllabus sets the tone for the course thereby helping students understand what is expected of them and how they can succeed in the course.

WHY IS A COURSE SYLLABUS IMPORTANT?

If properly utilized, a course syllabus will help you plan your semester efficiently and help limit confusion and stress. In short, a course syllabus will indicate what you as a student will be expected to do in a course, and how your performance throughout the course will be evaluated and graded. Common questions about a course can often be answered by reading and understanding the course syllabus.

USE THIS CHECKLIST TO GO THROUGH THE COURSE SYLLABUS FOR EACH OF YOUR CLASSES

Does the syllabus...	Yes/No	If yes, what do you need to do/write down?	If not, what should you do?
List the professor's preferred title? Do they want to be called Dr., Professor, first name, etc?			
Indicate when office hours are and how to access them?			
Help you understand how to communicate with the instructor outside of class?			
EXTERNAL RESOURCE REQUIREMENT			
Indicate what the required text(s) are?			
Identify software that is needed?			
Let you know if there is a course website or moodle page?			
Indicate what you should bring to class with you every day? (eg. computer or text book)			
Identify places you can go to get help or support with the class materials?			
COURSE DESCRIPTION - KNOW WHAT TO EXPECT SO THERE ARE NO SURPRISES			
Let you know what the course is about? What topics will be covered in the class?			

Does the syllabus...	Yes/No	If yes, what do you need to do/write down?	If not, what should you do?
POLICIES			
Indicate what the attendance policy is? (and what to do if you need to miss class?)			
Let you know how to deal with unexpected situations like: - Family emergencies? - A broken arm that prevents you from taking notes?			
Let you know what to do if you are told by a doctor you cannot attend class?			
Indicate what the expectations are for academic integrity?			
Inform you about how your final grade will be calculated? (Including if scores are dropped?)			
Indicate the number-letter grade equivalents (eg $\geq 90\%$ = A; ≥ 500 pts = A) used in grading the class?			
Let you know how you will be able to see grades on assignments?			
Inform you of if/how you can submit late work and how grades on late work are calculated?			
COURSE SCHEDULE AND DUE DATES			
Include lecture and lab times(s) and locations?			
Inform you of the exam schedule?			

Helpful tips:

- Always refer back to the syllabus - read before you reach out
- Check out these videos for more detailed information on how to best utilize your course syllabus: [How to Read a College Syllabus - And Strategize for How Best Approach the Course](#) and [What to do with your college syllabus](#).